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Listen in to *Park Singers* at Nageswara Rao Park

Park Singers will be felicitated today by Sangeetha Kalaimamani S. N. Surendar



The group meets almost every day at a corner in the park.

VARSHA SATHYANARAYANAN

A park is often seen as a space for physical exercises and casual conversations. At Nageswara Rao Park in Mylapore, this idea has evolved, and the space has become a vibrant centre for community engagement. Regular aerobics sessions promote well-being and the weekly Thiru Vi Ka public speaking forum encourages visitors to hone their communication skills.

In this setting, a professional singer and Mylapore resident, Ram Surender, discovered hidden musical talent among fellow walkers and nurtured these voices, beginning with a Christmas pro-

gramme in December 2025 that drew wider participation.

Today, we have close to 40 singers under "Park Singers," creating a unique musical community that even performed in a studio setting. A good number of members in the group are from Thiru Vi Ka Speakers' Forum that meets at Nageswara Rao Park. T. Narayanaswamy, a retired banker and a regular visitor to the park, keeps the group together, coordinating various activities and bringing new walkers to the group.

We typically croon to film songs of the 80s and 90s. This group has not only helped us widen our circle of friends but also enabled us to identify our talent. I have been afraid of singing before

an audience and stayed a "bathroom singer" for many years. With encouragement from Surender uncle, I finally gathered the courage to sing in front of others and recorded a full song in a recording studio. Now, I want to continue singing, not to impress, but to express myself.

Sangeetha Kalaimamani S. N. Surendar will distribute shields to the participants on March 29, 2026 at 10.30 a.m.

Park Singers meet every day between 9.30 a.m and 11.30 a.m and the spot near the men's gym is where we practise.

(Varsha Sathyanarayanan is a French language teacher, a member of Park Singers and a resident of Mylapore)

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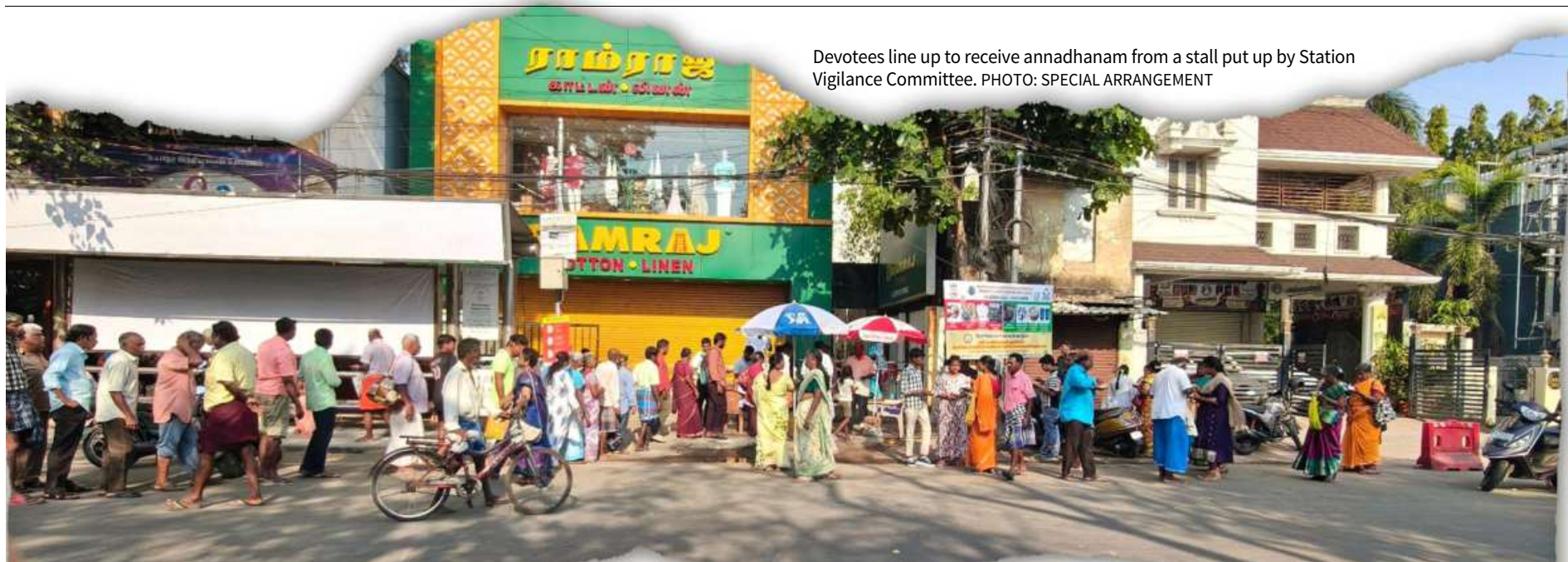
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Devotees line up to receive annadhanam from a stall put up by Station Vigilance Committee. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Annadhanam organisers are tweaking the menu or restricting distribution to certain days of the 10-day festival

LPG shortage casts shadow on Panguni Peruvizha

LIFFY THOMAS

The LPG shortage has cast a shadow on the ongoing Panguni Peruvizha at Kapaleeswarar Temple in Mylapore, with many caterers not accepting orders for distribution as part of annadhanam and those who have are tweaking their menu, populating it only with items that take minimal time for cooking. They are also resorting to firewood cooking.

The 10-day festival began on March 23 and annadhanam (free food) counters around the Mada Streets put up by devotees is a way of giving back to their Lord.

This is the third year that the Station Vigilance Committee (SVC), a voluntary group assisting the police in managing crowds during the festival, is participating in annadhanam, with sambar idli and ice cream brought into the menu.

The volunteers had put up a tough search for a caterer who

would cook on firewood. "On March 25, we distributed 5,000 sambar idlis, with idlis prepared from a kitchen in Thoraiyakkam and sambar from Keelkatalai," says G.G. Sivakumar, volunteer with SVC and coordinator, Nithya Pushpakainkaryam at Sri Kapaleeswarar Temple. Food is the staple at the festival but to offset the shortage ice cream has been brought into the menu. "Initially, we thought of serving variety rice on one of the days, but we changed that plan and switched to ice creams," says Sivakumar, adding that 400 litres of ice cream and 5000 idlis will be brought for distribution on March 29.

Cooking sambar rice or any variety rice, he says, takes more time, so we settled for sambar idli.

Days 7, 8 and 10 usually witness maximum people offering annadhanam, and some like Mylapore resident Viji Ganesh have decided to skip these days as there are many devotees coming with food.

The family was planning butter-

milk and variety rice, but decided to replace the latter with biscuit packets and sundal.

After two caterers declined to prepare for Sri Rama Navami and Panguni celebration at Ragamalika Apartments in Mandaveli, they found one who agreed to prepare for a gathering of 75 people. "This person is using a combination of LPG and firewood," says Kalyani Muralidharan, a resident of the community. She has been visiting the Panguni festival all these days and agree the annadhanam counters are less in number than previous years. "Usually devotees prepare chapathi or puri on the eighth day, we have to see if these items are being changed," she says.

A few caterers *The Hindu Downtown* spoke to say given the current LPG situation, they cannot take up annadhanam orders even if it is something as simple as offering curd rice. Many of them do not have the space to take up cooking with firewood.

Besides the deployment of 900 conservancy personnel, 200 college students have been brought on board to create awareness about keeping the festival litter-free

Urbaser Sumeet scales up campaign

Solid waste management company Urbaser Sumeet is running a massive drive to ensure the Panguni festival in Mylapore is litter-free. It has deployed over 900 personnel alongside 200 student-volunteers from Ramakrishna Mission Vivekananda College and KCG College of Technology to lead awareness drives and assist in clean-up activities.

The goal is to collect and recycle over 10 tonnes of waste this year, which is much higher than last year, said a press release.

It has placed 100 high-capacity (120-liter) bins, 40 BOV bins, and 30 audio-enabled vehicles for real-time public announcements. The firm has partnered with the "Bottles for Change" initiative by Bisle-ri and shop owners along the Mada streets.

To tackle waste before it hits the ground, the team has conducted awareness sessions for over 300 annadhanam stalls and 200 commercial establishments. All vendors have been issued official ID cards and received specialised training to ensure that food distribution does not result in waste pile-up, the release said.

In the release, Mahmood Sait, CEO of Urbaser Sumeet, said: "We want to make this festival cleaner and greener with everyone's support."

The campaign focuses on behavioural change through interactive IEC activities. For instance, a bin-



A temple themed selfie booth would ask devotees to take a "cleanliness oath".

shaped mascot will engage younger devotees and motivate them to use waste receptacles. Check out the temple-themed selfie booths, located at the temple on the final day, these booths would allow devotees to take a "cleanliness oath" and share the message of a litter-free festival.

Digital screens at the venue will showcase real-time waste clean-up and the efforts of the conservancy staff, the release added.

FROM THE SIDELINES

An eco-friendly message



Have you noticed these boards/banners at strategic points around the Kapaleeswarar Temple in Mylapore? There are at least 40 of them. Lions Club of Chennai Thirumylai, attached to District 3241C, has adopted this initiative to sponsor these campaign material that reminds public to use eco-friendly items during the festival and to keep litter at a minimum. The Club has bought eco-friendly garbage bags, paper plates and other items needed for the event and given to different stakeholders including shops and Urbaser Sumeet. The Club has thanked Lion A. Viswanathan, who is the main sponsor along with contributions from Lions Club of Thirumylai and Equitas Bank-Mylapore.

Socks given to devotees

Ther or car festival is an important part on the 10-day festival, where devotees gather to pull the chariot carrying deities barefoot in the scorching sun. To give some relief to those involved in this sacred ritual and taking part in the procession, Station Vigilance Committee is distributing socks.

"We distributed 500 pairs of socks on the third day of the festival and will be distributing another 500 on the seventh day," says K.S. Shankar, Convenor, Stations Vigilance Committee



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The pink route to empowering women

On March 31, Rotary District 3234 will be distributing its second batch of pink autos to beneficiaries it has selected with a fine-tooth comb

LIFFY THOMAS

These bright pink autos have become a familiar sight on Chennai roads. Driven by women and catering primarily to women and children, pink autos are on the rise thanks to various social organisations and a scheme promoted by the Social Welfare and Women Empowerment Department of the Tamil Nadu Government to fund women (partially, in most cases) to own and drive these vehicles.

The pink fleet ticks several boxes: women empowerment, women's participation in the labour force, promoting a clean environment (CNG is used as fuel) and breaking gender stereotypes.

According to ballpark figure, Chennai must be having more than 500 pink women autorickshaw drivers and this number is only on the rise.

On March 31, Rotary District 3234 will be distributing its second batch of pink autos, close to 27 (its second major drive after it launched the project in August 2025 to distribute 100 pink autos in an event held at Chennai Trade Centre).

The District engages the service of ANEW (Association for Non-Traditional Employment for Women) to identify and train deserving women. Basics of martial arts and communication skills are also covered under the training.

"Our beneficiaries have to update us at least once a month about the status of their EMIs. So far, we have 85 who are prompt in doing that," says Siva Ilango van, chairman - Pink Auto Project, Rotary District 3234.

Supporting drivers

Rotary District 3233 initiated the Pink Auto Project in 2019 and till date has given away 153 autos for women. Rotarian Shanthi Sel-



(Right) Shanthi Selvam, chairperson of the Pink Auto Project, Rotary District 3233, with a beneficiary. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Under the project, women auto drivers train aspiring candidates. "Jothi Lakshmi, for instance, one of our first beneficiaries has trained many women, many a time spending money from her own pocket and has bought her own house with her income. Likewise, Saritha from Ashok Nagar goes to other localities to offer classes," she says.

To ensure these women have a steady income, the Club associates with various Interact and Rotract Clubs.

"Rotary Club of Madras North West is under our umbrella. We connected Selvi, residing in the area, with the Club who was put in touch with Velankanni School in Ashok Nagar that has an Interact Club. Students who needed transport now use her service," says Shanthi.

Associating with a social organisation also means these women enjoy other benefits. "Rajan Eye Hospital has tied up with us to offer free eye care for all pink auto drivers and their families, including funding their cataract surgeries," says Shanthi.

Tough rules

According to Tamil Nadu Motor Vehicle Rules, only women are authorised to operate pink autos. To be eligible to apply for an auto under the Pink Auto scheme of the State Government, a woman must be between 20 and 45 years of age. P.V. Raji Ashok, a senior auto driver from Perambur, feels having a cut-off restricts many deserving women from entering the field.

She also feels it is unfair to take action if pink autos are operated by men. "My neighbour met with an accident the day she brought the pink auto and could not drive for six months. How will she repay the loan?" she asks.

There should be some authority these women can approach to seek exception when they cannot drive for genuine reasons, says Raji, who has been an auto driver since 1998.

vam, who has been chairperson of the project since its inception, says one of the biggest success stories of the project is that none of its women beneficiaries have sold their autos despite various challenges on and off the road. That is because they follow a rigorous process in selecting the most deserving persons (single women and widows are accorded preference in the selection process) and support them till they manage a steady income. Driving these vehicles is a big step toward financial independence for these women.

Of the ₹3 lakh purchase cost of an auto run on CNG, 50 percent is

borne by the Rotary District and the rest by the beneficiary who takes a bank loan, which is to be repaid by her in instalments.

"For women whose CIBIL score does not qualify them for a loan, we arrange for the loan by tying up with a private financial institution," says Shanthi, adding that they give away pink autos as and when they find sponsors.

"Finding sponsors is a challenge, and we have not reached out for CSR funds," she says adding that these women can earn between ₹1,500 and ₹ 2,000 a day.



For women whose CIBIL score does not qualify them for a loan, we arrange for the loan by tying up with a private financial institution



Mega career counselling fair on April 11 and 12

Conducted by
The Hindu
EducationPlus,
the fair is in its
23rd edition

The *Hindu Education-Plus* is conducting the 23rd edition of The Hindu EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair 2026 on April 11 and 12 from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m. at the Chennai Trade Centre, Convention Hall.

The exhaustive fair for parents and students from classes 9 to 12 will empower aspiring young minds to make informed career decisions from 40 plus institutions and help them choose the right courses and colleges. Top educational and financial institutions from across India will be present. Furthermore, career guidance sessions with domain experts will help people dis-

cuss their career plans.

This annual fair is a great chance for students and parents to explore different career paths, learn about college admissions, and gain insights into various fields of

study.

A plethora of options awaits students as they get ready to finish their schooling, much more than ever before. There is a wide range of courses to choose from,

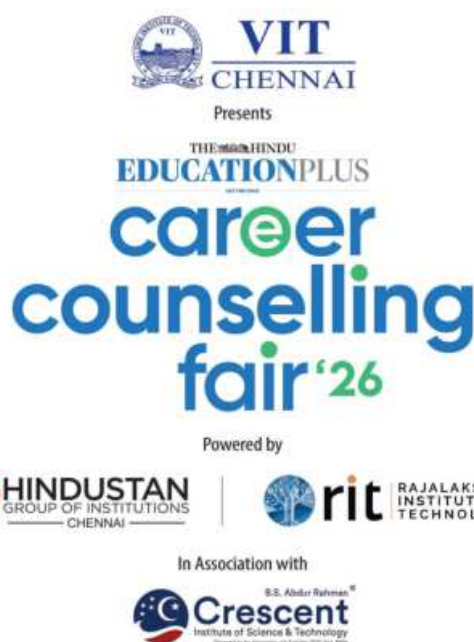
careers to aspire to, and areas of interest to delve into. In every edition, the fair has aimed to give students insights into several areas, cater to their interests, and open a world of educational opportunities for them.

The latest edition of the career Counselling fair will have all of this and make this experience possible for students by giving them the platform to engage with experts across diverse fields and representatives from various educational and financial institutions. Keeping up with the needs of the students, *The Hindu Education-*

Plus has been organising career expos to aid students looking to pursue higher education both in India and overseas.

Spot admissions and scholarships await the students at the fair along with surprise gifts for the first 200 entries on both the days. To know more about the sessions and the fair, contact: +91 90940 41021, 9962226550 and 9841298938.

“VIT Chennai presents The Hindu - Education Plus Career Counselling Fair 2026” is powered by Hindustan Group of Institutions,



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A message by New College students



Students of The New College in Royapettah did a formation as part of an awareness initiative by the Election Commission, urging citizens to ensure 100% voter turnout in the upcoming Assembly elections. PHOTO: RAGU R

Tea entrepreneur shares his lessons



Super Chennai's Arattai featured home-grown entrepreneur Jahabar Sadique, co-founder & CEO of Chai Kings, in a recently held session that brought together aspiring entrepreneurs and students.

In a candid conversation, he shared the story behind building one of Chennai's most recognisable tea brands, along with lessons from his entrepreneurial journey, challenges faced and the evolving consumption culture of the city, says a press release. He reflected on how Chai Kings emerged as a bold idea in a city traditionally known for its deep-rooted filter coffee culture. His journey resonated strongly with the audience, particularly young entrepreneurs looking to build purpose-driven ventures, adds the release.

Super Chennai Arattai is an initiative from Super Chennai, a city-wide, citizen driven branding movement, serves as an interactive platform that brings audiences closer to the individuals shaping the city's identity. The initiative offers an opportunity for citizens to connect with leaders across business, culture, sports and public life, adds the release.

The *swap* code

This has nothing to do with computer programming, but with an initiative that encourages participants to consider doing a swap on household items that might have outgrown their home but still has a place in somebody else's. Welcome to three online groups started by sustainability enthusiast and volunteer Swathi Ramanathan

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Perfectly usable furniture, electronic goods, utensils and books often end up discarded because households have outgrown them. While volunteering for waste collection drives Kasturba Nagar resident Swathi Ramanathan regularly came across this anomaly and felt prompted to start two online groups, both with a WhatsApp and Telegram presence, that encourage swapping over shopping, wherever that is possible, and give gently used household items and books a new address where they are cherished all over again. In addition, following a discussion in one of these swap groups, she also formed a group where participants can learn about free wellness programmes much before they are rolled out.

Swap Don't Shop

At last count, around 1,500 residents of Chennai follow that imperative, always asking themselves whether they can swap and not shop. A WhatsApp-based initiative that spilled over to Telegram, the group enables swapping of household goods. Born on 15 July 2024 in WhatsApp, where it has hit the ceiling being packed with 1025 members, Swap Don't Shop has had to find an additional home in Telegram, where it commands the following of over 500 members. The author of the initiative, Kasturba Nagar resident Swathi Ramanathan, felt the need for this group while coordinating waste collection drives as a volunteer of Residents of Kasturba Nagar Association (ROKA). During these drives, she repeatedly noticed items still in good condition being discarded. "We saw many usable household items being thrown away. We believe a product has to be used till its lifetime comes to an end," says Swathi. Initially launched as a clothes exchange group by Swathi along with Vaishnavi Venkatesh, the platform was later expanded to include all household items after the early model failed to gain traction.

Transactions follow clear guidelines: only household items without expiry dates are allowed, and plants are welcomed. Members post photos with detailed descriptions, including brand, age, dimensions, condition, price, and pickup location. Delivery is coordinated directly between

buyer and seller, occasionally involving porters for larger items. The platform has enabled beneficiaries ranging from domestic help needing textbooks and study guides to expatriates seeking short-term household items like Golu dolls. While logistical challenges, pricing issues, and trust concerns occasionally arise, Swathi believes the initiative finds itself sustained by a sense of community and purpose felt by members.

Chennai Book Bridge

Chennai Book Bridge is a Diwali gift to those who still swear by the physical book, while also consuming information digitally. Again, the idea of starting this group occurred to Swathi during waste collection drives. She came across many people who wanted to part with their books, but only with those who will cherish those books. She decided on starting a book-swapping WhatsApp group, which has now grown to nearly 300 members, most of whom are senior citizens and regular readers who prefer physical books. Beyond book exchange and donations, the group encourages discussions on authors, genres, literary events, and book-to-film adaptations, creating an interactive reading community. Swathi notes that these discussions have become a defining feature. "It is a lovely group... there are so many things I myself didn't know about authors and books," she says.

Although a Telegram version was introduced to organise discussions by genre, participation remains stronger on WhatsApp due to the older user base. Challenges, such as reselling low-value books or managing occasional rude behaviour, are moderated with clear guidelines emphasising good faith. Swathi elaborates, "We cannot control everything, but we ensure the platform remains respectful and focused on reading."

Nalam Chennai Wellness Connect

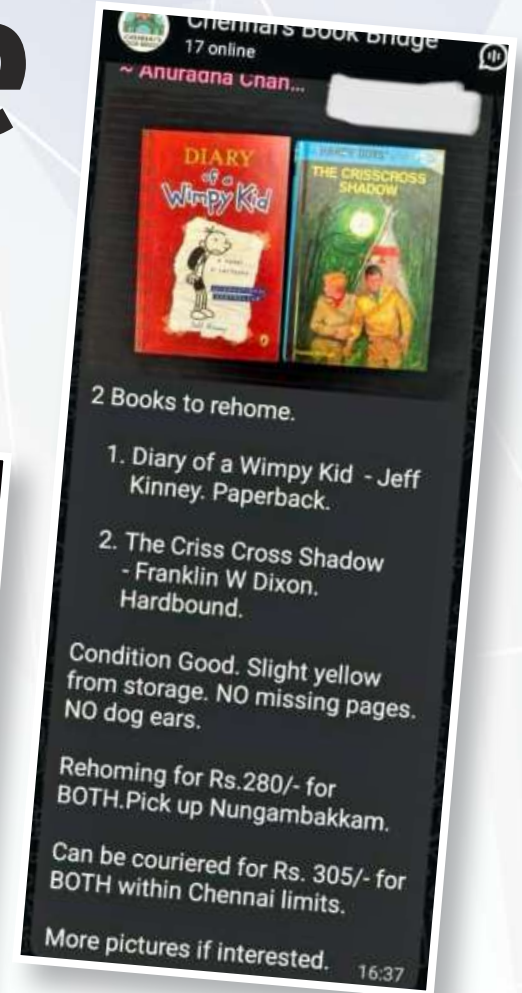
Free wellness camps have a way of eluding timely notice. Often times, they come to light as a post-event report in a website or a newspaper. Nalam Chennai Wellness Connect, present on WhatsApp and Telegram group, is an effort to bring visibility to free wellness programmes (yoga classes, health camps and so on) much before they start rolling so that people can attend and benefit from

them. Free yoga classes, free health camps

The idea began as an offshoot of the Swap Don't Shop initiative. "We wanted to brainstorm with participants about their interests. One of the interests was the wellness group. They said they wanted to know more about what was happening in the city in terms of wellness."

Members themselves can share details of free wellness services, provided the information is authentic. Swathi has shared updates on government initiatives, like free HPV vaccinations for adolescents. Currently, the group has 87 members on WhatsApp and 21 on Telegram, forming a small but growing network connecting Chennai residents to wellness opportunities that won't cost them a rupee.

For joining any of these groups, contact Swathi Ramanathan at 93812 02054



A cleanup to celebrate Bihar Diwas

The sands at Marina Beach get spruced up

Bihar Chaupal Chennai, the cultural wing of Ekatvasutra India Foundation, commemorated Bihar Diwas with a large-scale beach cleaning drive at Marina Beach. The initiative gained further significance as it coincided with World Water Day, reinforcing the message of environmental sustainability and water conservation.

Hundreds of enthusiastic members of Bihar Chaupal Chennai actively participated in the drive. Inspired by the ideals of Swachh Bharat Abhiyan and aligned with the vision of Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat, the initiative symbolised unity in action. Volunteers worked tirelessly to clean the beach, raising awareness about the importance of maintaining clean public spaces



and protecting marine ecosystems, said a press release. Dr. Ashish Kumar, founder

and Sutradhaar, highlighted that celebrating Bihar Diwas in Chennai reflects the deep cultural

connection and unity between states, embodying the true spirit of a diverse yet united India.

Assistive devices distributed at camp

Sri Kanyaka Parameswari Arts and Science College for Women, in association with Bhagwan Mahaveer Viklang Sahayata Samiti (BMVSS) and Surana and Surana Public Charitable Trust, conducted a mega Jaipur foot camp recently. Sponsored by DP World, the three-day camp was aimed at providing free assistive devices and rehabilitation support to persons with disabilities across Tamil Nadu, said a release. L.Sundaresan, Additional Solicitor General of Tamil Nadu, graced the valedictory function.

A total of 634 registrations were received from beneficiaries representing various districts of Tamil Nadu. Following thorough medical assessment and evaluation, individuals were identified as beneficiaries, receiving customised mobility and support aids based on their specific needs, said the release.

In total, 915 assistive devices such as artificial limbs, artificial hands, calipers, crutches, wheelchairs and tricycles were distributed free of cost.

The camp also served as a platform to raise awareness about disability inclusion, rehabilitation services, and the importance of assistive technology in enabling dignified living.

Chettinad Vidyashram wins laurels at Bulbul mahotsav



The Cubs & Bulbuls team of Chettinad Vidyashram brought laurels to the school by winning the overall trophy at the National Level Cubs and Bulbul Mahotsav held from March 10-14, 2026, at Rajasthan State Divisional Training Centre, Bikaner. Organised by Bharat Scouts and Guides National Headquarters, the event saw participation from teams across the country.

Students showcased talent in various activities like Grand Salute, Jungle Dance, Six Corner, Story-telling, Group Dance, Play-acting, and Drawing. The team won several prizes, contributing to their overall victory, said a release.

The event's theme was "Nurturing Young Roots in the Golden Sands of Bikaner."

A space for shared healing

On March 21, Golden Butterflies Children's Palliative Care Foundation conducted its third Grief and Bereavement Circle 'Finding Strength in Loss' at Madras School of Social Work College, bringing together 10 families in a safe and compassionate space to remember, reflect and connect.

The session created an environment where parents could express their emotions openly, while also finding strength in one another's presence. The event featured a special address by Dr. R. Vijalakshmi, Professor and Head, Department of Cancer Biology and Molecular Diagnostics, Cancer Institute. Having walked a similar journey herself, her reflections resonated deeply with the families, making her presence especially meaningful and comforting, said a release.

Golden Butterflies Children's Palliative Care Foundation conducted its third grief and bereavement circle

Participants engaged with a series of reflective stations designed around the theme of food, memory, and shared experiences. The Food Memory Installation invited families to reconnect with their loved ones through memories of meals, tastes, and everyday moments. An audio station offered a quiet space for personal reflection, while a reflection table with prompts encouraged participants to express thoughts, memories, and emotions in their own way.

release.

This initiative aims to provide students with global exposure and build skills in diplomacy, public speaking, and leadership.

For more details, visit: www.symedu.in
Contact: 8056024029

Selection for MUN Europe

Speak Your Mind is organising the 'MUN Europe Selection Programme' to identify students who can represent India at an international conference. The selection rounds will be held on May 15

and 16 at Career Launcher, Alwarpet.

The top 10 delegates will be selected to represent India at MUN Europe, scheduled to take place in Malta from October 7-9, 2026, said a

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R. RAGU

Artisans in Chintadripet specialising in lace garlands are going beyond the regular run-of-the-mill specifications. Even customisations through the year will fit certain patterns, monotonously recurring.

Customisations currently being pursued follow a whole new pattern. This is a pattern that repeats once every few years. These artisans are now putting faces to the lace gardens, powerful faces. Based on orders from political parties in Tamil Nadu, they personalise the lace garlands and kritams (crowns) with the faces of leaders of those institutions.

Power art

The lace garlands woven by the artisans in Chintadripet take on a new character ahead of elections

The colours of party flags are woven into the lace garlands.

The lace garlands are qualified as sandalwood lace garlands as scented sandalwood shavings are part of what goes into their making.

These wood shavings are also crafted into decorative items that jazz up the garlands. There are also

lace garlands that use cardamon to define the character of their strings.

The kritams (crowns) are made taller by artfully stacking currency notes, which is essentially about the party going the extra mile, a costly mile at that, to honour its leaders and candidates.

The makers of lace garlands are



In Chintadripet, a shop making lace garlands and crowns is customising them currently for political parties. PHOTOS: R. RAGU

artisans with an expertise that has been passed down the generations; and their shops are found on two streets in Chintadripet, namely Ayya Street and Arunachalam Street.

These families are also part of Chintadripet, youngsters taking the baton from their seniors and forbears, as is the case with Thulasi

Sha with a shop on Ayya Street.

There are two sets of artisans in these two streets of Chintadripet, one specialising in lace garlands, and other in those wide, elaborately embellished temple umbrellas. The peak season for the sale of temple umbrellas is October or the Tamil month of Puratasi.

Vocational awards presented

Rotary Club of Chennai Tower, a unit of Rotary International District 3233, organised its annual vocational service award event recently.

According to a press release, N Silambarasan, better known as "Silambam Silambu" from Ponneri was presented with Vocational Service Award - Young Achiever in Sports in recognition of his expertise in martial art, Silambam.

The Vocational Service Award - Social Service was presented to Selvaku-mar, a tailor from Virudhunagar. He has trained a large number of underprivileged women in tailoring with an aim to empower them for a fee of ₹1.

S Padma, a 48-year-old conservancy worker from Chennai was presented with Vocational Service Award - Epitome of Ethics Icon for the prompt return of 45 sovereigns of gold jewellery that she discovered during her



duty. The award aims to honour her exceptional honesty.

Nimal Raghavan, an engineer-turned-environmentalist, was honoured for his work on conservation of lakes. He was presented with Voca-

tional Service Award - Environmental Preservation.

Vocational Service Award - Lifetime Achievement was presented to Bharatanatyam exponent Leela Samson, adds the release.

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